representation in over thirty countries in the Indo-Pacific, as well as the aforementioned trade ties.

Any strategy for the Indo-Pacific must be comprehensive in nature, given American interests and commitments in the region. Strategy begins with appropriate means for achieving political ends. This means ensuring the robust nature of America's multifaceted institutional presence, both civilian and military. Reducing the US diplomatic or security presence undercuts attempts to play an engaged role that helps shape regional conditions.

The very size of the Indo-Pacific, with more than half of the world's population, along with its complexity, political diversity, and numerous problems, means that no one power can dominate the region, as seems possible in a smaller, territorially contiguous realm like Europe. But if absolute control is impossible, hegemony too is difficult, even for great powers in Asia. The traditional Asian great power, indeed even hegemon in early modern times, was of course China, with India playing a dominant role in its subregion. Utilizing political and economic power, ideology, and military power when necessary, Chinese dynasties from the Han (second century BCE–second century CE) onward sought to and often succeeded in structuring political relations and trade routes, propped up client states, and either battled or bought off barbarian tribes that threatened its borders.[43] By the mid-nineteenth century, however, attempts at reform had failed, European imperialism had sapped Chinese strength, and Chinese power had collapsed. In response, from the end of the 1800s through 1945, a newly modernized Japan attempted to build a colonial empire that would make it the dominant state in the Indian Ocean region and the South Pacific.[44]

Given this complex history, America's post–World War II strategy was comparatively ambitious. Washington's goal for the Indo-Pacific was reconstruction of battle-scarred countries, political and socioeconomic reform of Japan, and prevention of the rise of another dominant, aggressive power in the region.[45] The core of US strategy since 1941, it may fairly be said, is to block the emergence of any hostile hegemon in